



THE UNIVERSITY OF
MELBOURNE

Computing and
Information Systems

ISYS90045 Professional IS Consulting

Seminar 2 The Engagement Life Cycle

Dr Rod Dilnutt

Learning Objectives



- Identify the Consulting Engagement Life-cycle
- Define the different phases in the life cycle
- Understand the purpose and deliverables of each phase
- Explore the 7 habits of effective consultants

Why do consultants exist?

Discussion exercise:

A bit of a recap – and setting the tone for today:

- Why do executives and organisations hire consultants?
- What are they looking for from this experience?

The Engagement Lifecycle

Engagement Lifecycle

How is work won and performed in consultancies?

- Depends on the type of engagement
- A typical flow is:



Icarus: Case study

You work for Icarus Consulting, a mid-tier firm specialising in IT project services, including project management, business analysis, design and testing and release services. You don't have developers to build products, but you have several trusted companies you sub-contract to.

As a Director, you are already busy managing several accounts – however, on a rare day in the office, a partner taps you on the shoulder, late on a Monday afternoon, to ask for your help...

To illustrate the process, we will step through a case study.

Engagement Lifecycle

Risk assessment and internal inquiry

- Are we allowed to do this work?
- What could happen if we take this work?
- Could we cause a significant outage?
- Would our final report be given to anyone else?
- Is the client reputable?
- Do we have the right people?

Engagement Lifecycle

Winning the work

- Review the RFI, EOI, RFT, RFQ
- Determine client requirements
- Identify who your bid team is
- How do we do this work?
- Prepare the response
- Review, review, review and sharpen
- Prepare for questions, consultations.

Engagement Lifecycle

Contractual negotiation

- Confirm budget
- Negotiate scope and legal clauses governing delivery.
- Sign Contract

Engagement Lifecycle

Delivery and project management

- Performing the work
- Kick-off meeting
- Ongoing project management (timeline and task completion, budget).
- Deploy Methodology

Engagement Lifecycle

Close-out and QA

- Review of outcomes with leaders
- Can include an internal legal review of deliverables.
- Final Presentation
 - Steering Committee
 - Sponsor
- Final iterations
- Sign Off

Should we bid?

Discussion exercise in groups:

Scenario 1

You have been invited to bid to provide testing services to help the implementation of a core banking system. This is a key engine behind their internet banking service. It is well-known in the press that this is so far a wildly unsuccessful and expensive project that has been running for years. You have never worked at the client before, but there would be a certain prestige for working with them.

Should you bid?

Should we bid?

Discussion exercise:

Scenario 2

You have been overseeing testing services for a small Government Agency for three years. Your client – the CIO, Benny Robinson – is a key promoter of Icarus. You have been invited to bid to provide project management and business analysis services. The Agency has been reliant on expensive contractors in this function that have not integrated well with generally efficient internal project teams. The contractors are being removed for the successful tenderer. This will be a three-month engagement while Benny sources a full-time team.

Should you bid?



Executive
summary

Introduction

Our
understanding
of your needs

Engagement
methodology
and timelines

Pricing and
assumptions

Team CVs

Similar work
we have
performed

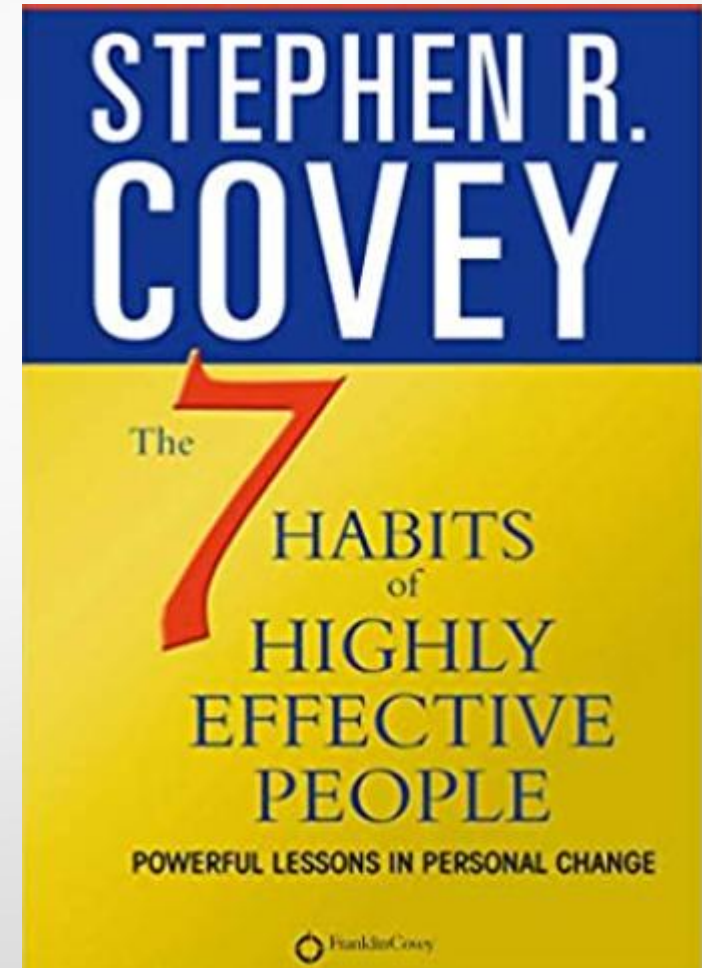
Seven habits of effective consultants

The seven habits

General insights into effective delivery of work

Help your team deliver their best by:

- ▶ Effectively managing stakeholders
- ▶ Ensuring the client 'buys in' to your solutions
- ▶ Building trust
- ▶ Giving teams the space needed to get the job done
- ▶ Helps with your own ongoing learning and development.



Habit One

Work with the client

- ▶ Use the target technical environment
- ▶ Keep your ear to the ground
- ▶ Test ideas with your client stakeholders
 - ▶ Are we asking the right questions?
 - ▶ Have we made the correct assumptions?
 - ▶ What is our working hypothesis?
- ▶ Maintain joint ownership
- ▶ Build relationships
- ▶ Be visible when working
 - ▶ Optics and taking an early lunch – people notice!

Habit Two

Manage the expectations of all the strategic buyers and clients

- ▶ Identify the real client
- ▶ Gives you the stakeholder chart for you to consider and use to start managing relationships.

Habit Three

Proactively manage the high-level relationships

- ▶ Governance
- ▶ Stakeholders.

Know who is who

Understand their drivers



Habit Four

Provide regular updates

- ▶ Enabled by status-type meetings
- ▶ Weekly with the 'real' clients outlining:
 - ▶ Burn-down charts to demonstrate resources remaining
 - ▶ Explains that you've achieved milestones
 - ▶ Demonstrates your direction: "We're now looking at producing this work stream"

Habit Five

Listen!

- ▶ Someone will always know the answer
- ▶ Do people have hidden agendas?
- ▶ How will your suggestions be received?
- ▶ How are your suggestions being received?

***Hint: At every meeting create a silence
and wait for the client to fill it.***



Habit Six

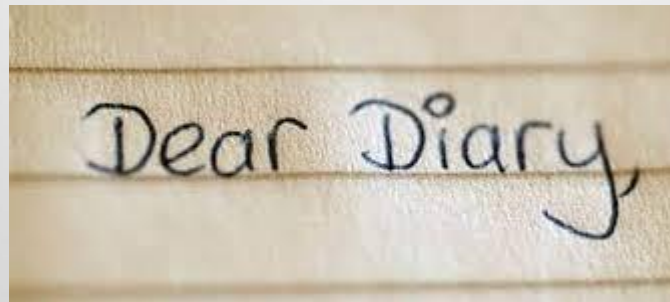
Take time out

- ▶ Allocate a percentage of working time to non-client work to enable:
 - ▶ Reflection
 - ▶ 'Sharpening the saw'
 - ▶ Support for and from colleagues
 - ▶ Marketing/ visibility
 - ▶ Perspective.

Habit Seven

Keep a diary or a record of your own work activities

- ▶ A supplement to project plans and reports
- ▶ Include:
 - ▶ Working hours
 - ▶ Key conversations and outcomes
 - ▶ Reflections
 - ▶ Frank, personal, secure
- ▶ Enable your ongoing learning in a structured manner
- ▶ Also gives you a prompt to look after yourself.



Bad Habit One: Showing Off

- Credentials
- Experience
- Name-dropping
- 'Value add'
- Unsolicited advice
- Knowing better

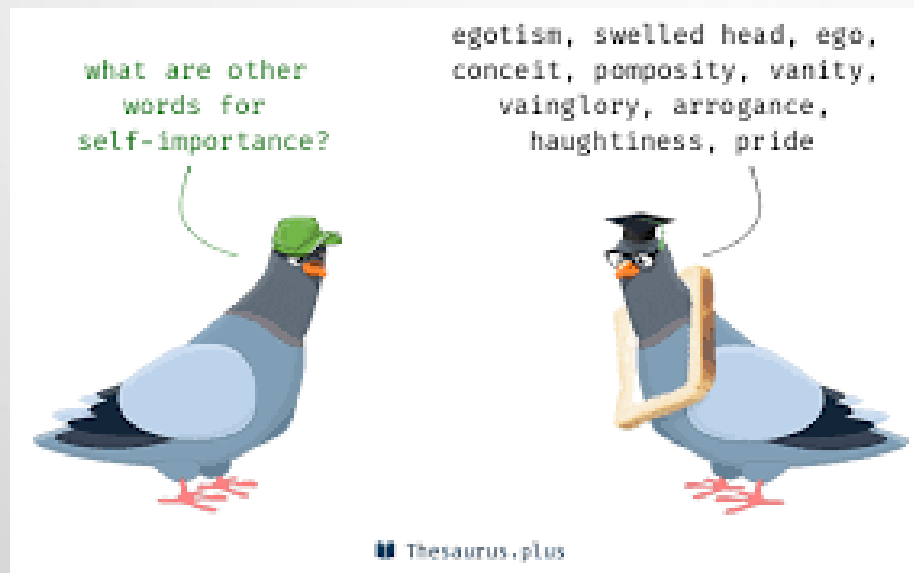


Bad Habit Two: Self-Importance

Over-investment in your own ideas

You've come up with a better solution than the client

- ▶ On the first day
- ▶ Great work, right?





THE UNIVERSITY OF
MELBOURNE

Computing and
Information Systems

7 Habits Highly Effective People



Summary

Be mindful of the seven habits:

- Work with the client
- Manage the expectations of all the strategic buyers and clients
- Listen
- Take time out
- Keep a diary or a record of your own work activities

Avoid bad habits

- Showing off
- Self importance

These help you and the deliver the best outcome for the client

- ▶ As well as yourself and the team.